



HAUNTED HOUSE: The Vidhan Sabha (left); Gaud's wrecked car

commissioned in the mid-'90s, the erstwhile housing and environment minister Satyanarayan Sharma had taken the lead in performing rituals to correct the *vaastu dosh* (violations).

When the building was first designed and built in the early 1990s, *vaastu* was not quite the rage it is today. Its exceptional design even won the world's biggest recognition for architectural excellence, the \$5,00,000 (Rs 2 crore) Aga Khan Award for Architecture in 1998. However, the exponents of *vaastu shastra* disagree with some of the key features of its design, especially the fact that its main entrance faces the south. Says Dharamdas B.J.D, a leading *vaastu* practitioner in the state, "The entrance should be from the east or north-east. Besides, some other features are off-key like the shape of the dome. This is a recipe for disaster as it denies the occupants peace of mind and, worse still, causes death."

Rationalists, however, beg to differ. Arun Bhargava of the NGO Science Centre (Gwalior), which coordinates

Children's Science Congress activities across the state, says, "This isn't about faults in architectural design but about avoidable human errors. Gaud was driving without a pilot car as prescribed by the protocol." Incidentally, all the six legislators who have died were from BJP and, bar one, all were sitting or former ministers. Asks Bhargava sarcastically, "So does it mean that being a BJP MLA or a member of the Shivraj Singh Chauhan Cabinet is hazardous to one's life and limb?"

Speaker Rohani has been wary of commissioning any correctional exercise lest it be taken that he was promoting or giving credence to religious mumbo-jumbo. The Constitution enjoins the state through the Directive Principles of State Policy to promote a scientific temper. Being associated with anything that can be tagged superstitious claptrap can put a body like the Vidhan Sabha in a sticky situation. Responding to the demands, Rohani says guardedly, "Life and death are in the hands of the supreme power." As the debate rages, MLAs of Madhya Pradesh are keeping their fingers crossed.

normally associated with the trappings of ancient Hindu traditions, has, in fact, taken a lead in this regard. The party's state unit president and MLA, Narayan Tripathi held a yagna at the MLA Rest House on February 16 to rid the building of the evil spell. It isn't the first religious ceremony of its kind according to Vidhan Sabha officials. Some time after the building was

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